



CATHERINE THE GREAT



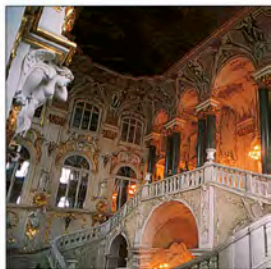
Catherine II, Empress of Russia during the 18th century, was called “Great” because she made Russia a great European power. She asked the advice of many of the major thinkers in Europe and, because she was interested in education, she started the Russian school system.

Catherine also loved clothes and spectacular entertainments, and so did her nobles. Under her rule they became even more powerful than they had been before. They were the owners of land and of people. These people were known as serfs and, like slaves, they had to do whatever their masters wanted. Serfs could be bought and sold by their masters.



Miserable existence

Nine out of ten Russians were serfs and life for them was grim. Often, they lived in poor log huts with only one room for an entire family.



Catherine’s palaces and the homes of the nobles were filled with furniture, ornaments, carpets, and other luxuries in the latest fashions.